

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

Leo, the Lion, and its brightest star Regulus (see p.253) are high in the northern half of the sky for all southern observers, with Castor (see p.276) and Pollux in Gemini lower in the northwest. Sirius (see p.252) still sparkles high in the western sky, but Orion sinks on its side toward the western horizon. Almost overhead for observers in midlatitudes is Alpherat, the brightest star in the constellation Hydra, which sprawls across an otherwise barren region of sky toward the southeast horizon.

Spica, the brightest star in Virgo, is well-placed in the east, and Canopus, in Carina, is prominent in the southwest sky. However, the main focus of attention is in the southeast, where the Southern Cross, Crux, now rides high along with brilliant Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri—Rigel Kentaurus (see p.252) and Hadar—which point toward it.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

An open star cluster popularly known as the Southern Pleiades, IC 2602 lies close to the meridian on March evenings. Its brightest member, 3rd-magnitude Theta (θ) Carinae, is easily visible to the naked eye, and binoculars reveal at least two dozen more members.

Four degrees to the north of the Southern Pleiades lies a large glowing region visible to the naked eye, NGC 3372, also known as the Carina Nebula (see p.247), which contains the erratic variable star Eta (η) Carinae (see p.262). Farther north, between Antlia and Vela, telescopes will pick up the planetary nebula NGC 3132, also known as the Eight-Burst Nebula. On view in the southwest sky are the Large Magellanic Cloud and the Tarantula Nebula (in Dorado).



THE FALSE CROSS

Two stars in Vela (top left and center right) and two in Carina (center left and bottom right) form the False Cross in the southern sky.

URANUS

